Relationship of Anthropology with Other Disciplines

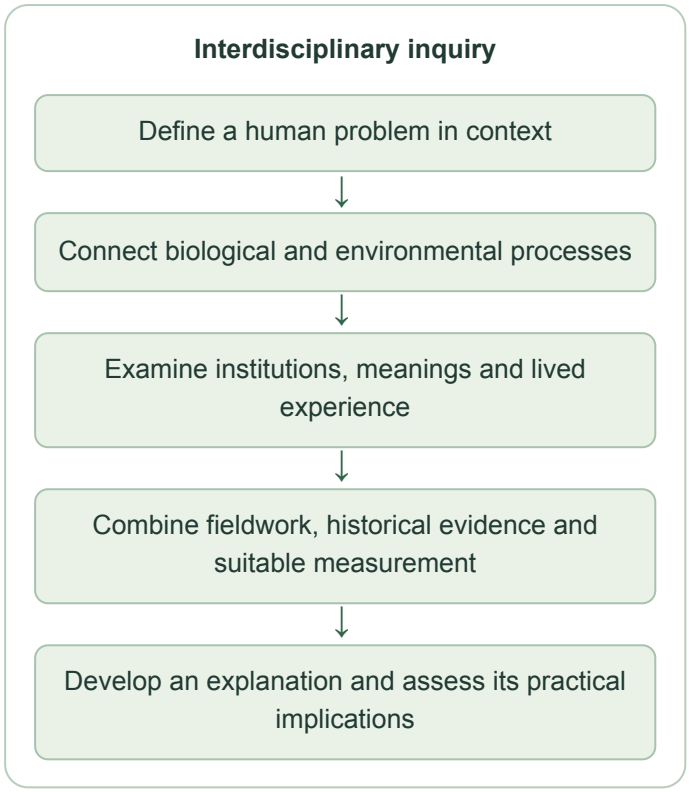
1. A bridge between sciences and humanities

Anthropology combines biological, social, cultural, historical and linguistic evidence to study humanity holistically. Its boundaries with other disciplines are overlapping, not watertight.

Orientation	Main emphasis	Anthropology's connection
Natural sciences	Biological/physical processes and testable explanations.	Evolution, genetics, physiology, primatology, dating and environmental analysis.
Social sciences	Institutions, relationships, behaviour and social change.	Kinship, economy, politics, religion, caste, gender and inequality.
Humanities / history	Meaning, experience, interpretation and historical context.	Cultural interpretation, oral histories, symbols and historical reconstruction.

- **Malinowski:** systematic field investigation and explanation of interconnected cultural institutions.
- **Radcliffe-Brown:** comparative study of social relations; social anthropology envisaged as a natural science of society.
- **S. F. Nadel:** systematic analysis of social structure and explanation.
- **Evans-Pritchard:** stressed historical/interpretive understanding and the humanities; this does not mean abandoning evidence.
- **Kroeber and David Bidney:** relevant to culture, history and philosophical questions; do not infer that biology and culture have “no meaningful connection”.
- **Ruth Benedict:** cultural patterns and interpretation; **Robert Redfield:** holistic connections across communities and wider civilisation.

Answer position: scientific explanation and humanistic interpretation are complementary resources. Anthropology is not compelled to become only a natural science or only a social science.



2. Anthropology and history

Dimension	Anthropology	History
Common concern	Human experience, continuity and change.	Human experience, continuity and change.
Typical emphasis	Cultural/social relationships and comparative or holistic explanation.	Contextual reconstruction and explanation of change over time.
Evidence	Fieldwork, oral accounts, material culture, archives and biological/environmental data as relevant.	Written records, oral histories, material remains and other critically assessed sources.
Contribution to the other	Everyday life, non-elite perspectives, kinship and cultural interpretation enrich historical accounts.	Chronology and historical context prevent treating cultures as timeless.

- Archaeology reconstructs past settlements, livelihoods and institutions; oral histories illuminate Indigenous and other under-recorded pasts.
- Study material culture to understand values and practices, not merely to list objects.
- **Avoid rigid claims:** historians do not study only political events; anthropologists do not rely only on observation. **Participant observation of living people cannot directly observe an extinct society**; historical inference requires appropriate evidence.

Example: combine an excavated settlement's layout, household artefacts, environmental remains and written/oral evidence to interpret its social organisation.

3. Anthropology and economics

Shared domain: production, distribution, exchange, consumption, resources and decisions. Economic anthropology asks how these operate within kinship, religion, gender, power and culture.

Anthropology adds	Economics adds
Cultural meanings of value, obligations and exchange.	Models of allocation, incentives, markets and distribution.
Non-market institutions, household work and local livelihoods.	Quantitative techniques and analysis of broader economic/policy relationships.
Field evidence on unequal access and lived consequences.	Tools for assessing resource constraints and policy outcomes.

- **Research themes:** gendered work; globalisation and local economies; poverty and inequality; varied exchange systems.
- **Marvin Harris, *Cultural Materialism: The Struggle for a Science of Culture* (1979):** material conditions, production and social organisation as explanatory concerns.
- Economic arrangements vary and change; one market model does not explain every form of exchange. Conversely, modern economics also studies institutions and behaviour—it is not concerned only with ideal rational optimisation.
- Understanding diversity does not imply that every economic arrangement is equally equitable or desirable.

Example: explain why a household's exchange obligation persists even when immediate monetary return is low; investigate kinship, reputation and reciprocal support.

4. Anthropology and political science

Shared domain: power, authority, governance, political participation, conflict and collective decisions.

Political anthropology often emphasises	Political science also contributes
Authority in everyday relationships; kinship, ritual and ethnicity.	Theories of government, the state, institutions and policy.
State and non-state political arrangements, informal power and local legitimacy.	Comparative analysis, political processes and broader institutional frameworks.
Community experiences of law, development and exclusion.	Tools for evaluating representation, governance and public decisions.

- Shared research: gender and participation; political systems across cultures; globalisation; democracy and development.
- Political arrangements change under economic and social pressures; no single institution can be understood apart from context.

- The difference is one of **emphasis and research traditions**. Political science also studies informal power; anthropology also studies states.
- Aristotle supplies a classical background to political thought; avoid claiming his work alone established modern political anthropology.

Example: a local council's formal rule may operate differently because kinship, gender and status influence who can speak and whose decision is accepted.

5. Anthropology and psychology

Shared domain: thought, emotion, learning, personality, behaviour and mental health.

Anthropology's contribution	Psychology's contribution
Cultural expectations, socialisation and situated meanings.	Theories and methods concerning cognition, emotion, development and individual variation.
Cross-cultural evidence questions the universality of findings from a narrow sample.	Experimental and other systematic approaches help examine mechanisms.
Inequality, community relationships and lived experiences of distress.	Assessment of individual and group processes, with cultural context increasingly incorporated.

- **Ruth Benedict and Margaret Mead:** culture-and-personality traditions; **Sigmund Freud:** psychoanalytic theories drew on interpretations of cultural material, whose assumptions need critical scrutiny.
- Research areas: childhood development; cultural shaping of self/personality and emotion; poverty and distress; cultural expression and interpretation of illness.
- Individualism/collectivism are analytical tendencies, not fixed labels that make everyone in a society identical.
- Culture affects experience and interpretation, but biology and individual agency also matter. Neither discipline owns a single level of explanation.

Example: understand an account of distress through personal circumstances, local idioms, social inequality and relevant clinical evidence rather than assuming the same expression everywhere.

6. Anthropology and sociology

Shared domain: social groups, institutions, relationships and social change. Their overlap is especially strong in contemporary research.

Traditional contrast	Qualification today
Anthropology often studied small-scale/non-Western communities; sociology often studied industrial societies.	Both now study villages, cities, organisations, migration and digital settings worldwide.

Traditional contrast	Qualification today
Anthropology emphasised intensive fieldwork and comparison; sociology often used surveys/statistical analysis.	Both use qualitative and quantitative methods.
Anthropology links society to culture, biology and deep time.	Social anthropology and sociology share substantial theoretical and empirical ground.

- Common questions: family and kinship; religion; gender; stratification/class and mobility; globalisation and institutional change.
- Sociology contributes theories of institutions, inequality and social processes; anthropology contributes contextual and comparative field evidence. Exchange is two-way.
- Religion, kinship and gender influence social behaviour, but systems are dynamic and internally diverse.

Example: combine household ethnography with a survey of migration and class mobility; link personal accounts to wider structural patterns.

7. Anthropology and medical sciences

Shared concern: health, illness and healthcare. **Medical anthropology** connects biological conditions with cultural meanings, social inequality, access and lived experience.

Medical anthropology contributes	Medical sciences contribute
Local understandings of illness and help-seeking.	Biological and clinical investigation of disease.
Trust, stigma, household decision-making and barriers to care.	Diagnosis, treatment and prevention evidence.
Social determinants and community evaluation of programmes.	Epidemiological and other methods for evaluating health outcomes.

- **E. E. Evans-Pritchard's Azande work:** shows how witchcraft, oracles and explanations of misfortune form a coherent cultural system. It is evidence about beliefs/social reasoning, not scientific proof of supernatural causes.
- Topics: poverty and unequal health outcomes; beliefs and care choices; globalisation and disease transmission; culturally appropriate interventions.
- **COVID-19** illustrates interconnected mobility, public communication and unequal exposure; **HIV/AIDS programmes** illustrate the importance of trust, stigma and accessible communication.
- Cultural sensitivity should improve evidence-based care; it does not make every explanation of disease biologically equivalent.

8. Write a comparative answer

Definition → shared concern → differences of emphasis → two-way contribution → example → convergence.

Use “traditionally”, “often” and “emphasis” where appropriate. Avoid absolute claims such as history = documents only, economics = money only, sociology = modern societies only, or psychology = biology only.

Relevant Mains questions

- **2013, 10 marks:** “How do you situate Anthropology in Social Sciences?” Discuss anthropology's holistic position, social institutions, natural-science links and interpretive methods. The source's wording is retained pending an original-paper check.
- **2016, 10 marks, about 150 words:** “Differences between Social Anthropology and Sociology.” Use the traditional contrasts and contemporary convergence above.
- **2014, 10 marks, about 150 words:** “Major sub-divisions of Anthropology.” Define the four fields, their methods and applied connections; the branches are elaborated in Chapter 3.

9. Quick recall

History—time; economics—livelihood/exchange; political science—power; psychology—mind; sociology—institutions; medicine—health. Anthropology connects each to cultural context and holistic human experience.